

Basilicas, secular and sacred

The Roman public hall or basilica is a rectangular building with side aisles behind rows of supporting columns. The oldest-known example was built in Pompeii in the second century BCE. Originally, the basilica was a hall of justice or commercial exchange; tribunals took place in the apse (a recess at one end), and offerings were made at the altar before business began. In 313 CE, Constantine recognized Christianity, and by 326 it had become the official religion of the Roman Empire. The three great churches founded by Constantine in Rome are all basilicas. Two of them, St Peter's and St Paul's, feature the transept, which crossed the nave near the altar end and gave more space for pilgrims or clergy. (It also turned the ground plan into the shape of a Christian cross.) Nave, aisles, transept and apse became common elements of rectangular Western churches. When Constantine moved the new capital of Rome to Byzantium, renaming it Constantinople, the empire stretched from Milan and Cologne to Syria, Greece and Egypt, building basilicas everywhere that reflected local ideas.



Ruins of the second-century Severan Basilica at Leptis Magna, a Roman city in modern Libya